



HOUSING RESEARCH REPORT

Women and Housing: Identifying Themes

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Women and Housing: Identifying Themes

A Literature Review

Prepared for: Pan Canadian Voices for Women in Housing Symposium

September, 2017

(rev. September 2018)

Executive Summary

This literature review explores the range of issues that impact women across the housing continuum—from shelters, through transitional and supportive housing, to safe, affordable housing—and pulls out related key themes. Women’s precarious housing and homelessness occurs in a context of continuing economic inequality of women and gender-based violence. Both these overarching factors argue for specialized transitional housing and nuanced design of second-stage housing for women. The study also underlines the additional burdens felt by women in at-risk populations such as Indigenous, immigrant and senior populations, those in northern and rural areas, trans persons and single parents. A bibliography of 40 recent publications on these topics is provided.

This paper was developed by Status of Women Canada, in collaboration with Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation, to support the consideration of gender and intersecting factors in housing policy. It was developed to inform the Pan-Canadian Voice for Women’s Housing Symposium, which took place in September, 2017.

Résumé

Cette revue de la littérature explore le large éventail de problèmes qui touchent les femmes dans l'ensemble du spectre du logement – des refuges aux logements de transition ou avec services de soutien, jusqu'au logement sécuritaire et abordable – pour en dégager les thèmes clés. Pour les femmes, l'itinérance et le logement précaire se présentent dans un contexte persistant d'inégalité du revenu des femmes et de violence fondée sur le sexe. Ces deux facteurs fondamentaux montrent l'importance de logements de transition spécialisés et d'une conception plus holistique des maisons d'hébergement transitoire pour les femmes. L'étude fait aussi ressortir le fardeau additionnel supporté par les femmes dans les populations à risque, comme les femmes autochtones et les immigrantes, les personnes qui vivent dans des régions nordiques ou rurales, les personnes trans, les mères de familles monoparentales et les femmes âgées. Une bibliographie de 40 publications récentes sur ces sujets est fournie.

Cette étude a été entreprise par Condition féminine Canada, en collaboration avec la Société canadienne d'hypothèques et de logement, dans le but d'appuyer la prise en considération de l'incidence de l'appartenance à un sexe et d'autres facteurs qui se recoupent dans les politiques de logement. Elle a été élaborée comme outil informatif pour l'événement « Parlons femmes et logement » : un symposium pancanadien qui a eu lieu en septembre 2017.



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This paper was developed by Status of Women Canada, in collaboration with Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation, to support the consideration of gender and intersecting factors in housing policy. It was developed in part to inform the Pan-Canadian Voices for Women in Housing Symposium, which took place September 13-15, 2017, in Toronto. This paper is not intended as an exhaustive review of the literature on this issue. It is based on a review of approximately 40 Canadian and international sources of relevance to the Canadian context. The review explored the range of issues that impact women across the housing continuum – from shelters to transitional and supportive housing, to safe, affordable housing – and pulled out related key themes.

Introduction

Research, policy interventions, and societal discourse have traditionally been insensitive to the gendered nature of housing and homelessness (Fotheringham, Walsh, & Burrowes, 2014). Indeed, definitions and understandings of homelessness do not adequately capture the nuances of women's housing instability and experiences with homelessness (Little, 2015). This lack of recognition and understanding ultimately impedes women's ability to navigate through and overcome these challenges, which is particularly problematic.

In light of this, a gender-based analysis that considers and includes the multifaceted needs of women in Canada is important to effectively understand and remedy women's housing concerns. The purpose of this literature scan, then, is to provide a limited overview of the complex and interconnected factors related to women's housing issues, with a particular focus on homelessness, precarious housing, and transitional housing. Given the heterogeneity of women, and, thus, the diversity of women's experiences, the relationship between housing experiences and intersecting identities will be explored. Moreover, this summary will briefly highlight promising practices to address women's issues and concerns in the delivery of housing and homelessness programs. Importantly, this paper does not serve as a comprehensive review of the breadth of factors that contribute to women's housing experiences.

Overarching Contextual Factors

Empirical research has uncovered several factors that contribute to women's access to adequate housing, many of which stem from systemic gender inequalities (Fotheringham et al., 2014). Two important factors that contribute to women's housing experiences and homelessness include gender-based violence and economic inequalities, both of which will be discussed in turn.

Gender-Based Violence

Gender-based violence is arguably the most significant factor contributing to women's experiences of housing instability and homelessness. Safe and appropriate housing, as well as the economic resources to maintain adequate housing, are of high importance to women attempting to flee an abusive relationship (Zufferey, Chung, Franzway, Wendt, & Moulding, 2016). Several studies have evidenced a strong association between experiences of intimate partner violence and subsequent housing instability (e.g., Rollins, Saris, & Johnston-Robledo, 2001; Tischler, Karim, Rustall, Gregory, & Vostanis, 2004).

Intimate partner violence often results in a host of issues that impede women's ability to secure and maintain suitable housing. For example, separation from an abusive partner may result in significant loss of income and savings, particularly for women who were

financially dependent on their partner (Baker, Niolon, & Oliphant, 2009; Pavao, Alvarez, Baumrind, Induni, & Kimerling, 2007; Zufferey et al., 2016). Many women are unable to afford housing expenses without their partner's financial support, and, consequently, may feel as though they have no choice but to continue living in an abusive household (Clough, Draughon, Njie-Carr, Rollins, & Glass, 2014), or, conversely, they (and their children) become homeless (Baker, Cook, & Norris, 2003).

In addition to the material housing insecurity that is associated with intimate partner violence, such experiences of violence may contribute to psychological housing instability. Women who have experienced violence in the home are often not afforded the safety, security and refuge that a home typically provides (O'Campo, Daoud, Hamilton-Wright, & Dunn, 2016). Rather, the home represents feelings of stress and danger (O'Campo et al., 2016). Accordingly, it is important for women who have experienced violence to not only obtain housing that satisfies material needs, but psychological needs as well, including safety, community, and comfort (Woodhall-Melnik et al., 2017). For women who have experienced intimate partner violence, "home" is also conceptualized as a place where they can live without fear of further victimization (Woodhall-Melnik et al., 2017). It is not altogether surprising then, that women who have experienced violence relocate both frequently and to lengthy distances in an effort to keep both their children and themselves safe (Zufferey et al., 2016).

Economic Inequalities

The inability to afford housing is a key contributor to homelessness, housing insecurity and instability. Low income, including low earnings from paid work, may inhibit women's likelihood of being able to access adequate housing for themselves and their children. Without question, there is a significant gender pay gap between women's and men's earnings for work of equal value: women (\$26.11 per hour) earn a significant amount less than their male counterparts (\$29.86 per hour; Moyser, 2017). In addition to the gender pay gap, women are over-represented in part-time and precarious (i.e., temporary or casual employment) work arrangements. Specifically, almost three-quarters of part-time workers are women (Moyser, 2017). Moreover, women tend to be clustered in occupations that are associated with low pay, with 21.2 per cent of women (vs. 17.3 per cent of men) who work full-time holding jobs with average hourly wages that are in the lowest 20 per cent of the wage distribution (Moyser, 2017). Additionally, women also spend more time on unpaid activities, such as taking care of children and other dependents, than their male counterparts (Phipps, Burton, & Lethbridge, 2001). Each of these factors contribute to an earnings disparity between women and men, which, in turn, contributes to women's housing insecurity and experiences with homelessness.

At-Risk Populations

A constellation of factors contribute to women's housing insecurity and experiences of homelessness. However, women in Canada are not a monolithic group. Rather, intersections of diversity (e.g., age, ethnicity, etc.) create unique experiences, including experiences of housing instability and homelessness, which disproportionately affect some individuals more than others. Accordingly, a discussion of the relative impact and implications of intersecting identities is warranted.

Gender Identity

Experiences of housing insecurity and homelessness are heavily influenced by gender expressions and identities. Trans persons are over-represented among those who are homeless, which may stem from their increased risk of experiencing poverty (Spicer, Schwartz, & Barber, 2010), as well as their exclusion in several areas, including the home, work, and school (Mottet & Ohle, 2003). Trans persons are often expected to embody a conventional feminine gender expression in order to access women-specific services, effectively excluding individuals who cannot or choose not to conform to binary gender expressions (Lyons et al., 2016). Those who are able to access women-specific housing services and shelters are often vulnerable to negative treatment (e.g. harassment) and safety concerns from other service users and staff (Lyons et al., 2016).

Geographic Location

Several factors contribute to northern women's experiences of housing instability and homelessness. The incidence of homelessness in northern communities is particularly impacted by the alarming shortage of housing in these remote areas (Schmidt, Hrenchuk, Bopp, & Poole, 2015). The low-cost housing that is available is often sub-standard (Falvo, 2011) and overcrowded (Abele, Falvo, & Hache, 2010; Tester, 2009). Added to this, it is not uncommon for the scarce amount of emergency shelters in northern communities to serve as permanent housing for many women due to a lack of transitional and second-stage housing in these communities (Bopp et al., 2007; Falvo, 2011). Not surprisingly, then, many of these shelters are overcrowded and understaffed (Yukon Anti-Poverty Coalition, 2011).

Indigenous Women

The likelihood of Indigenous women becoming or remaining homeless is linked to several individual and systemic issues, such as the experience of intimate partner or family violence, mental illness, substance misuse, pregnancy, and involvement with the criminal justice system (Schiff & Schiff, 2010). The legacy of colonialism and subsequent intergenerational trauma play an important role in Indigenous women's experiences of housing insecurity and homelessness (Patrick, 2014; Brave Heart, 2003). Geographic location and Indigenous background also intersect to

disproportionately affect Indigenous women living in rural and northern communities: up to ninety percent of homeless women in the North are of Indigenous descent (Bopp et al., 2007).

Immigrant Women

Immigrant women are also at an increased risk of experiencing housing insecurity. Immigrant women's housing is often substandard (Leloup & Zhu, 2006) and located in declining neighbourhoods (Carter & Osborne, 2009; Carter, Polevychok, & Osborne, 2009). This housing insecurity has been linked to inadequate income (Walsh, Hanley, Ives, & Hordyk, 2016), which may be a function of immigrant women (and women more generally) working in precarious and low-paid employment (Kissoon, 2010; Vosko, 2006). Added to this, immigrant women may be unfamiliar with the local housing system (Walsh et al., 2016). Further, some immigrant women have no choice but to continue living with their sponsor (i.e., partner or family member) in order to maintain their immigration status, which may serve as a barrier to leaving the household, whether abusive or otherwise (Bui, 2003).

Senior Women

It is not uncommon for senior women in Canada to experience housing insecurity and homelessness. Senior women are often troubled with economic insecurity, which may stem from limited pension benefits, little or no retirement savings, or widowhood (McDonald, Donahue, Janes, & Cleghorn, 2006), among other things. These factors may increase the likelihood of senior women finding themselves in a precarious housing situation. It is not altogether surprising, then, that increasing numbers of senior women are seeking shelter. For example, in 2016, there was a twenty per cent increase from the year prior in the number of women over the age of 50 and approximately a thirty per cent increase in women over the age of 60 who sought shelter in Ottawa (Alliance to End Homelessness Ottawa, 2017).

Lone-Parent Families

The predominance of women-headed lone-parent families is staggering. In 2016, almost 80 per cent of lone-parent families were headed by women (Statistics Canada, 2016). Single mothers may face significant barriers in securing and maintaining affordable, adequate housing, including their dependence on a single income and lower average earnings (Lauster & Easterbrook, 2011). In 2011, 34 per cent of women-headed lone-parent families were classified as low income, higher than any other family type, including lone-parent families headed by men (Statistics Canada, 2011). Single mothers, particularly those with low incomes, employ various coping strategies to avoid homelessness. For example, they are often faced with choosing between paying the rent, paying for utilities, or buying food and medications (Greene et al., 2010; Kirkpatrick & Tarasuk, 2011). In addition, single mothers may resort to housing that is inadequate

in size in an effort to avoid living in shelters or unsafe neighbourhoods (Greene et al., 2010).



Figure 1. The Housing Continuum

Implications and Future Directions

Reflecting on the overarching factors that contribute to women's housing instability and homelessness, several important issues must be addressed in order to effectively intervene. One prominent theme in the existing literature is the important role that transitional housing plays in ending homelessness for women (Fotheringham et al., 2014). (See Figure 1.) Specifically, the counselors and 24 hour support that accompanies transitional housing are key in providing women with the resources necessary to navigate through their housing-related challenges (Fotheringham et al., 2014; Walsh et al., 2010; Washington, 2002).

Women who have experienced intimate partner violence are often dealing with co-occurring challenges, such as mental health issues, financial and employment instability, a lack of social support, as well as issues surrounding childcare (O'Campo et al., 2016). However, research on women's housing issues and intimate partner violence may not sufficiently address the complexity of these co-occurring challenges (Pavao et al., 2007). The collective impact of these simultaneous issues must be considered when attempting to understand the housing experiences of women who have experienced violence at the hands of their partners, as well as homeless women more generally.

Importantly, efforts aimed at reducing and preventing women's housing instability and incidence of homelessness must take an intersectional perspective. For example, in order to obtain appropriate housing, immigrant women may also need support and services that address language and employment barriers (Thurston et al., 2006). Indigenous women may benefit from alternative methods of support that are cognizant

of traditional, spiritual and cultural customs (Gone, 2010; Walsh, Rutherford, & Kuzmack, 2009). Indeed, women's divergent experiences demand that interventions and programming aimed at addressing women's housing issues be mindful of the unique needs of women with intersecting identities.

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